

How are we to live?

Ages 11-16

*Evidence-based pointers on living well —
each with how it was tested, how big the effect is, and its
weakest point.*

Trust but verify

"Trust but verify" is an old phrase, and it is the whole method of this site. It means: don't be a cynic who believes nothing, and don't be a pushover who believes everything — **believe things in proportion to the evidence, and go look at the evidence yourself.**

So every health page here comes with its workings on show:

Trust but verify (cont.)

- **How good the evidence is** — a badge on each page says plainly how strong or shaky the proof is, and the page names its own weakest point. A page that hid its weaknesses would be doing exactly what we criticise.
- **Which clock it's on** — the *ten-year clock* means the next ten years of your life; the *seventy-year clock* means your whole life ahead, roughly the next seventy years. A risk on the ten-year clock could hurt you soon; one on the seventy-year clock builds up slowly and mostly shows up decades later. Which one it is changes how much it should matter to you right now.
- **The actual sources** — the studies are named so you can look them up. You don't have to; the point is that you *could*. And if a science word gets in the way, [Words we use](#) explains it.

Trust but verify (cont.)

Information is power in a very literal sense: a lot of products are designed to be easy to start and hard to stop, and they work best on people who never check the evidence. Checking is the move that puts you back in charge.

Smoking kills, stopping helps

If you look at what actually harms people your age in this country, smoking is not near the top. The things most likely to seriously hurt or kill a teenager are **accidents — especially on the roads — and self-harm**. Cigarettes belong to a much slower clock: they mostly harm people decades from now.

But your teens are exactly when that slow clock gets *started*, and it is exactly when nicotine gets sold to you — now mostly as vapes. So two honest things at once:

Smoking kills, stopping helps (cont.)

- **Vaping nicotine is not the same as smoking.** Cigarettes harm you by *burning* — the smoke is full of the chemicals that do the long-term damage. A vape does not burn, so it delivers far fewer of those chemicals. Anyone who tells you a vape is "just as bad as a cigarette" is wrong, and once you know that, you will stop trusting the rest of what they say. That is why being straight with you matters.
- **But for someone who has never smoked, starting to vape is pure loss.** You would be taking on an addiction with nothing to trade for it — vapes have only existed since around 2007, so nobody can honestly promise you they are safe over a lifetime, because that lifetime hasn't happened yet.

Smoking kills, stopping helps (cont.)

What you do now shapes the whole rest of your life. **Not starting removes almost the entire future risk, at no cost to you.** It is the single most valuable health decision you can make — and it matters most right now, because this is exactly when the addiction is designed to catch you.

And if someone you love already smokes, this matters for them too: quitting is genuinely hard, but it is **not** just willpower. Proper help — medicines plus support — makes success far more likely, and it is never too late. They do not have to do it alone.

Alcohol: no safe dose

Here is the thing the lifetime-cancer statistics miss: for someone your age, **the risk from alcohol is tonight, not thirty years away.** The real dangers are immediate and physical — injury, being hurt in a fight, drowning, choking, passing out, and things that get done to you or by you that cannot be taken back. That is a completely different, and much closer, kind of harm than liver disease decades from now.

Alcohol: no safe dose (cont.)

One honest point to hold onto: **there is no amount of alcohol that is good for you** — the idea that "a glass of red wine is healthy" turned out to be a mistake in how the old studies were done. But be fair too: for an adult, the extra risk from *one* drink is small. The honest message is that the risk starts at the first drink and grows with every drink after it — not that one drink is deadly.

What you do now matters for later too — but the more useful message for you is the near one: the danger you can actually see coming is the same night, not decades away.

Gambling: designed so you lose

The most dangerous gambling products are the ones **on your phone**, and they are designed that way on purpose: fast, endless, always open, a new bet every few seconds. Speed and never stopping are what make a product hard to put down, and plenty of people your age already gamble.

Here is the part nobody can argue with, and why this one needs no complicated science:

Gambling: designed so you lose (cont.)

- **The "house edge" is published.** The *house edge* is the share of every pound bet that a game is built to keep, on average, over time. On a roulette wheel it is just under 3p of every £1. For games like roulette or an online slot, the company states it in the rules or the terms and conditions. It is a guarantee, not a guess.
- So the honest line is: **you are not unlucky — you are on the wrong side of a number the company chose in advance, wrote down, and published.** Nobody has to cheat you. The edge is in the terms and conditions.

Gambling: designed so you lose (cont.)

What you do now matters because the habit, and the harm, follow the *product*, not your personality — the faster and more non-stop the game, the more people it hurts. The defence is not out-willpowering a well-built machine; it is declining to play a game whose maths you have now seen.

Eat food. Mostly plants. Not too much.

Two blunt facts first, because they are the point:

Eat food. Mostly plants. Not too much. (cont.)

- **Excess body fat causes disease.** It is not just about looks — higher body fat really does *cause* a higher risk of type 2 diabetes, heart disease and several cancers, and shortens life on average. This is one of the better-proven things on the whole site: studies using genes show it is cause and effect, not just two things that happen to go together.
- **The biggest risk factor for carrying excess weight later is carrying it now.** Weight tends to stay with you from childhood into adulthood, and once the body has gained fat it *defends* it — after weight loss, the body burns less energy and the weight tends to come back. Losing it is genuinely hard; not gaining it is far easier.

Eat food. Mostly plants. Not too much. (cont.)

Put those together and the useful move is obvious: **don't get there in the first place** — and that is far more about your surroundings than your willpower. The amount you eat is partly down to the food itself: in the best experiment on this, the same people ate a lot more when the food was processed, without trying to. It is also down to *how much is put in front of you* — give people bigger portions and they reliably eat more, without feeling any fuller. So the levers you actually control come before you feel hungry — what is in the kitchen, what is easiest to grab, and how big the serving is (a smaller plate, not seconds by habit). Change the defaults and the eating changes with them.

Move more, sit less

The science here is genuinely encouraging:

- The single biggest gain of all comes from **moving out of the least-active group**. If you do almost nothing now, a little regular movement buys you more than a very fit person gains by training even harder.
- You need **less than most people think**. Most of the benefit arrives well before any big daily target.

Move more, sit less (cont.)

So there is nothing you have to "hit" and no membership to buy. Whatever movement you can stick with — a sport, a walk, a bike ride — gets you most of what matters. What you build now is a habit that keeps paying off for decades, but even judged on today it is the most winnable item on this whole site.

Move more, sit less (cont.)

And the payoff is not only decades away. Regular activity is one of the most reliable ways to lift a low mood and take the edge off stress and anxiety — something you feel in days and weeks, not decades. There is even genetic evidence that being more active *causes* lower rates of depression, not just that cheerful people happen to move more.

Move more, sit less (cont.)

One concrete, free option worth knowing about: **parkrun** — a free, weekly, timed 5 km run *or walk* in a local park, open to anyone and deliberately welcoming to complete beginners (plenty of people walk it). It rolls the two benefits into one cheap package: movement, plus a bit of outdoor social contact. It is a neat example of the whole idea — not "try harder," but an easy, low-cost option that makes the good choice easy.

Sleep like it matters

First, the fact that earns you a bit of fairness: **teenagers' body clocks genuinely run late.** As you go through puberty, the chemistry that makes you sleepy arrives later in the evening. A 15-year-old who can't fall asleep at 10pm isn't being lazy or difficult — they are being 15. That is biology, not a character flaw.

Sleep like it matters (cont.)

Now the useful part, and notice what it is *not*: it is not "sleep or you'll die young." The honest pitch is that **sleep is the best-proven quick way to change how you actually feel** — your mood, your attention, your ability to handle a bad day. Lose sleep and those get measurably worse; get it back and they recover.

And the fix is often about your **surroundings, not effort**: when a real school pushed its start time later, students slept more and did better — nobody had to "try harder." So the fixable part isn't blaming yourself for the hours you can't get; it's protecting the ones you can.

Sleep like it matters (cont.)

The things that actually protect sleep are boringly practical, and they are about your surroundings more than your character: keep roughly regular hours, a dark and cool room, **dim the bright screens in the hour before bed** (bright evening light pushes your body clock even later), and keep caffeine — energy drinks especially — **out of the afternoon and evening** (it disrupts sleep even six hours before bed). None of that is willpower; it's just setting the stage.

Slip, slop, slap

Most items on this site are about risks decades away. **This one is different — it is already relevant to you.** A serious skin cancer called melanoma is one of the *commonest* cancers in people aged 15–34 in the UK. So this is one of the rare cases where "now" and "in fifty years" point the same way.

Two things worth knowing:

Slip, slop, slap (cont.)

- The action is genuinely easy — sunscreen, a shirt, shade — and it is backed by a proper experiment where people were split into groups by chance, which is rarer than you'd think for this kind of advice.
- **Sunbeds are officially on the top list of things proven to cause cancer** ("Group 1") — the same list as tobacco. A tan from a sunbed is selling you exactly what the evidence warns against.

What you do now shapes your future risk in a clear way here: sun damage adds up over a lifetime, and in the experiment the protection was still visible a decade after it ended. Small habit, lasting effect.

Change the rules, not just yourself

The whole site argues one point: change your **surroundings**, not your willpower. But someone builds those surroundings — and before long, that someone includes you.

The biggest health lever isn't only your own habits; it's the rules and the surroundings everyone shares. Real examples that worked: banning smoking indoors, a minimum price on alcohol, the "sugar tax" that made drinks less sweet, safer routes to cycle. None of these asked anyone to try harder — they changed the defaults for everyone.

Change the rules, not just yourself (cont.)

So here is the honest, empowering version, and it is the opposite of "not my problem": **as you grow up, getting involved and voting for governments and representatives who make healthy choices easier becomes one of the most powerful health decisions you can make.** Not to blame yourself for the world you inherited — but to use the say you are about to get, for yourself and the people around you.

Five things to remember

1. **Don't start nicotine — cigarettes or vapes.**
2. **No amount of alcohol is good for you — and for you, the danger is tonight.**
3. **Gambling apps are built so you lose.**
4. **Move in any way you'll keep doing.**
5. **Protect your sleep with your surroundings, not your willpower.**

Trust, but verify.

Full evidence — with the study designs, the effect sizes, and the honest weaknesses — is on the site.

Information is power.